under Major General Kulwant Singh was set up to study the military implications arising from the Chinese occupation of Tibet. The committee clearly stated that Chinese aggression was a distinct certainty in the next five to seven years, that is, between 1959 and 1961. The Kulwant Singh Committee recommended that India should immediately increase the force levels on the Indo-Tibetan border. Despite this, during the run-up to the Panchsheel Treaty, not once was the army asked for its assessment of the situation. Nehru, who viewed Mullik as a hawk and suspected his hand in the Tawang affair also, kept the IB chief out of the loop.

The word ‘Panchsheel’ denotes the ‘Five Taboos’ in the ancient Buddhist scriptures governing the personal behaviour of monks. This was suggested by Nehru to Chou En-lai, China’s first premier, as the ‘Five Principles of Peaceful Co-existence’ that would be applicable to international behaviour of modern states. Considering the fact that the future of the Tibetan people who had been subjugated by military force was at stake, the preamble was ironic. The Chinese premier gleefully accepted the treaty which not only recognized China’s possession of Tibet but, in fact, legalized it. Additionally, while allowing for trade with the Chinese government in Tibet, the Indians gave up their right over numerous facilities that existed in Lhasa and along the trade route that linked the Tibetan capital to Kalimpong in West Bengal. The Indian infantry detachments at both Gyantse and Yatung and the Indian Mission in Lhasa were to be withdrawn.

Nehru and his team were also under the mistaken notion that if they specified in the treaty the passes through which trade would be held, the boundary between the two countries would be defined. This was not accepted by the Chinese who claimed that all the major passes named in the agreement—Shipki-la, Mana, Niti, Kungri Bingri, Dana and Lipulekh—were well to the north of their claim line.

The reason for India not insisting on reciprocal concessions while recognizing China’s suzerainty over Tibet can only be understood in the context of the ‘Hindi Chini bhai-bhai’ spirit of the 1950s where Chinese and Indian leaders swore ‘eternal peace and friendship’. Prime Minister Nehru felt quite satisfied having got a written guarantee of good behaviour from China. The treaty was signed on 29 April 1954 at Peking. This, in hindsight, was a diplomatic coup for China. From India’s point of view, it was a